

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	FULL MOON	NEW MOON
2020	April 8	April 23
2021	April 27	April 12
2022	April 16	April 1, 30
2023	April 6	April 20
2024	April 23	April 8
2025	April 13	April 27
2026	April 2	April 17
2027	April 20	April 7

PLANETS

2022: April 5 Mars and Saturn appear about half a Moon-width apart in the low eastern predawn sky.

2022: April 29 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.5.

2022: April 30 Venus and Jupiter appear half a Moon-width apart in the low eastern predawn sky.

2023: April 11 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.3.

2025: April 21 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.6.

2025: April 29 Venus and Saturn appear seven Moon-widths apart in the low eastern predawn sky.

2026: April 3 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.5.

ECLIPSES

2022: April 30 A partial eclipse of the Sun is visible from the southeast Pacific and south South America.

2023: April 20 An annular total eclipse of the Sun is visible from Indonesia, Australia, and Papua New Guinea. It begins annular, farther along its path becomes total, and ends annular.

2024: April 8 A total eclipse of the Sun is visible from Mexico, central US, and east Canada. A partial eclipse is visible from North and Central America.

APRIL

One of the most familiar patterns in the sky, the seven stars that make up the Big Dipper lie overhead from mid-northern latitudes, with the crouching figure of Leo, the Lion, reigning farther south. In the eastern sky, the daffodil-colored Arcturus, in Boötes, announces the arrival of spring in the north. In southern latitudes, the Southern Cross lies close to the north-south meridian, and Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri—Rigil Kentaurus and Hadar—are high in the southeast.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

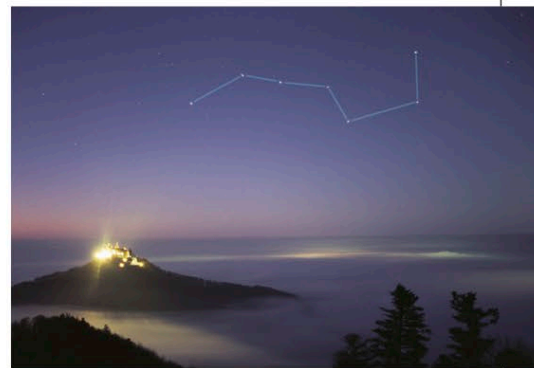
THE STARS

On April evenings, the Big Dipper is high in the sky. The stars in the bowl point north to Polaris (see pp.278–279), the north Pole Star, while following the curve of its handle leads to Arcturus, in Boötes, which is the brightest star north of the celestial equator. Continuing this curve leads to Spica, the brightest star in Virgo, close to the southeastern horizon. South of Leo and Virgo, the sprawling figure of Hydra occupies a large but mostly blank area of sky. By April, most of the stars of winter have disappeared in the west, although Gemini remains on view and Capella, in Auriga, twinkles in the northwest.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M81 (see p.314), the beautiful spiral galaxy in northern Ursa Major, is well placed for observation this month. A

large open star cluster worthy of attention can be found in Coma Berenices and consists of a scattering of stars of 5th magnitude and fainter fanned out over an area of sky several times wider than a full moon. Known as the Coma Star Cluster, this is best viewed through wide-angle binoculars. To its south is the Virgo Cluster (see p.329); a telescope is needed to see its numerous but faint member galaxies.



THE BIG DIPPER

The familiar shape of the Big Dipper can be seen high in the sky on northern spring evenings.

METEOR SHOWER

One of the weaker annual meteor showers, the Lyrids reaches its peak around April 21–22, when a dozen or so meteors per hour can be seen radiating from a point near Vega (see p.253) in Lyra. Although not numerous, Lyrids are bright and fast. Rates are highest toward dawn, when Vega is highest in the sky, and they are much lower for a day or so on either side of the peak.

NEPTUNE

